

SPUNTI: ITALIANO ELEMENTARE 2



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Spunti: Italiano elementare 2

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This text was compiled on 09/25/2025

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1.01: L'avverbio e il pronome "ci"

The adverb and pronoun ci

Consider the following example:

- Giovanni: Siete andati in montagna domenica?
- Davide: Sì, **ci** siamo andati. Bellissimo!

Ci means **there** *or in/to/at the place* that has already been mentioned. In the example above, **ci** stands for **in montagna**. We use **ci** to avoid repeating the name of the place. Whereas in English we often do not necessarily need to say **there**, in Italian it is obligatory to say **ci**.

Now consider the following example:

- Giovanni: Riesci a finire il tema per domani?
- Davide: Sì, **ci** riesco, non ti preoccupare.

With verbs such as **riuscire a** [*to manage to; to be able to*], **credere a (in)** [*to believe in*] and **provare a** [*to try to*], **ci** can replace a word or phrase introduced by the prepositions **a** or **in**. In the example above, **ci** stands for **finire il tema**.

Ci always goes before the conjugated verb, i.e.: *ci vado, ci sono andato*, etc. However, when there is a verb + an infinitive, it can go either before the conjugated verb or be attached to the end of the infinitive after you have dropped the last letter of the infinitive, as in **andare** > **andar**. Consider the two possible answers to the following question:

Sei già andato al nuovo ristorante in via Roma?

- No, ma **ci** **voglio andare**.
- No, ma **voglio andarci**.

Espressioni molto usate:

- **ci** **credo** [*I believe it; I believe in it*]; **non ci** **credo** [*I don't believe it; I don't believe in it*]
- **ci** **riesco** [*I can do it*]; **non ci** **riesco** [*I can't do it*]
- **ci** **provo** [*I try*]
- **provaci!** [*Try!*]

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1.02: I verbi riflessivi e reciproci

Reflexive and reciprocal verbs

Many verbs are reflexive in Italian, that is, they describe an action that you do to yourself, such as *to wash your hands* [**lavarsi le mani**] or *to wake yourself up* [**svegliarsi**]. Italian verbs tend to use the reflexive form more often than English verbs, so many verbs that are reflexive in Italian are not reflexive in English, such as **lamentarsi** [*to complain*] and **arrabbiarsi** [*to get angry*]. Reflexive verbs in the **present tense** are conjugated exactly like all verbs in **-are, -ere, -ire**, with the addition of a reflexive pronoun.

Present tense

arrabbiarsi [<i>to get angry</i>]	perdersi [<i>to get lost</i>]	divertirsi [<i>to have fun</i>]
[io] mi arrabbio	[io] mi perdo	[io] mi diverto
[tu] ti arrabbi	[tu] ti perdi	[tu] ti diverti
[lui, lei, Lei] si arrabbia	[lui, lei, Lei] si perde	[lui, lei, Lei] si diverte
[noi] ci arrabbiamo	[noi] ci perdiamo	[noi] ci divertiamo
[voi] vi arrabbiate	[voi] vi perdetevi	[voi] vi divertite
[loro] si arrabbiano	[loro] si perdono	[loro] si divertono

Notice that **ci** means both *there* (as you have just learned) and *us/to us/ourselves*.

Passato prossimo

In the **passato prossimo**, all reflexive verbs take *essere* as the auxiliary. As for all verbs that take *essere* in the *passato prossimo*, a singular female subject will say **mi sono persa a Venezia**, a masculine plural subject will say **ci siamo persi a Venezia**, etc.

arrabbiarsi	perdersi	divertirsi
[io] mi sono arrabbiat o/a	[io] mi sono pers o/a	[io] mi sono divertit o/a
[tu] ti sei arrabbiat o/a	[tu] ti sei pers o/a	[tu] ti sei divertit o/a
[lui] si è arrabbiat o	[lui] si è pers o	[lui] si è divertit o
[lei] si è arrabbiat a	[lei] si è pers a	[lei] si è divertit a
[noi] ci siamo arrabbiat i/e	[noi] ci siamo pers i/e	[noi] ci siamo divertit i/e
[voi] vi siete arrabbiat i/e	[voi] vi siete pers i/e	[voi] vi siete divertit i/e
[loro] si sono arrabbiat i/e	[loro] si sono pers i/e	[loro] si sono divertit i/e

Reciprocal verbs describe an action that two or more people do to or with each other, and they take the same form as reflexive verbs. Reciprocal verbs are always conjugated in the plural forms of the verb, because they always involve two or more people. Consider the conjugation of verb **abbracciarsi** [*to hug each other*] in the present tense and in the *passato prossimo*:

present tense	passato prossimo
[noi] ci abbracciamo	[noi] ci siamo abbracciati
[voi] vi abbracciate	[voi] vi siete abbracciati
[loro] si abbracciano	[loro] si sono abbracciati

A list of the most common reflexive and reciprocal verbs:

<u>REFLEXIVE</u>		<u>RECIPROCAL</u>	
accorgersi / rendersi conto di	<i>to realize</i>	abbracciarsi	<i>to hug each other</i>
addormentarsi	<i>to fall asleep</i>	amarsi	<i>to love each other (romantically)</i>
allenarsi	<i>to practice (a sport); to train for</i>	aiutarsi	<i>to help each other</i>
alzarsi	<i>to get up</i>	baciarsi	<i>to kiss each other</i>
annoiarsi	<i>to get/be bored</i>	conoscersi	<i>to know each other; to meet for the first time</i>
ammalarsi	<i>to get sick; to fall ill</i>	incontrarsi	<i>to meet</i>
arrabbiarsi	<i>to get angry</i>	innamorarsi	<i>to fall in love with each other</i>
chiamarsi	<i>to be called</i>	lasciarsi	<i>to break up (to leave each other)</i>
comportarsi	<i>to behave</i>	odiarsi	<i>to hate each other</i>
dimenticarsi di	<i>to forget to</i>	parlarsi	<i>to talk to each other</i>
divertirsi	<i>to have fun</i>	salutarsi	<i>to greet each other</i>
farsi	<i>to make, to do for oneself</i>	scriversi	<i>to write to each other</i>
fermarsi	<i>to stop</i>	sposarsi	<i>to marry each other; to get married</i>
lamentarsi	<i>to complain</i>	telefonarsi	<i>to call each other</i>
lavarsi	<i>to wash oneself</i>	vedersi	<i>to see each other</i>
mettersi	<i>to put on</i>	volersi bene	<i>to love each other (not romantically)</i>
perdersi	<i>to get lost</i>		
preoccuparsi	<i>to worry</i>		
prepararsi	<i>to get ready</i>		
ricordarsi di	<i>to remember to</i>		
rilassarsi	<i>to relax</i>		
riposarsi	<i>to rest</i>		
sedersi	<i>to sit</i>		
sentirsi	<i>to feel</i>		
svegliarsi	<i>to wake up</i>		
trovarsi	<i>to find oneself</i>		
vergognarsi	<i>to be ashamed</i>		
vestirsi	<i>to get dressed</i>		

Notice that many reflexive and reciprocal verbs also have non-reflexive and non-reciprocal forms, which you already know and have used before. Compare:

PERDERE Ho perso le chiavi. <i>I lost my keys.</i>	PERDERSI Mi sono perso a Venezia. <i>I got lost in Venice.</i>
AIUTARE Aiuto la mamma in cucina. <i>I help my Mom in the kitchen.</i>	AIUTARSI Io e la mamma ci aiutiamo in cucina. <i>My Mom and I help each other in the kitchen.</i>
TELEFONARE Telefoni spesso a Carlo? <i>Do you call Carlo often?</i>	TELEFONARSI Tu e Carlo vi telefonate spesso? <i>Do you and Carlo call each other often?</i>

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1.03: Quando

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1.04: Normalmente

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1.05: Che cos'hai fatto nel fine settimana?



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2.01: L'imperfetto

The imperfect tense

You have already learned the **passato prossimo** (*ho studiato tutta la mattina; siamo andati in discoteca ieri sera*, etc.). The **imperfetto** is another past tense in Italian. How do you know when to use *passato prossimo* or *imperfetto*? Here is the rule:

Always use the *passato prossimo* except for the following situations:

to describe the way people, objects, places, the weather, situations and states of mind <u>were</u> in the past.	Da piccola ero molto riservata. [<i>When I was a child I was very reserved.</i>] Non avevamo molti soldi nel 2015. [<i>We did not have a lot of money in 2015.</i>] Sabato scorso faceva così freddo! [<i>Last Saturday it was so cold!</i>]
to describe what <u>used to happen</u> in the past on a regular basis. In this sense, the <i>imperfetto</i> is analogous to “<u>used to</u>” in English.	Mio padre lavorava per la FIAT. [<i>My dad used to work for FIAT.</i>] Da piccolo non mi piaceva fare i compiti. [<i>When I was a child I didn't like to do my homework.</i>] D'estate andavamo al mare. [<i>In the summer we used to go to the sea.</i>]
to describe what someone <u>was doing</u> or what <u>was happening</u> when something else happened. In this sense, the <i>imperfetto</i> is analogous to “<u>was/were + -ing</u>” in English.	Mentre camminavo, ho visto un cane abbandonato. [<i>While I was walking, I saw an abandoned dog.</i>] Luca studiava mentre noi guardavamo la TV [<i>Luca was studying while we were watching TV.</i>] Che cosa facevi nella mia cucina? [<i>What were you doing in my kitchen?</i>]

Key expressions that usually require the use of the *passato prossimo*:

quando (with the connotation of *at the moment when*)
 parlato del suo problema.

all'improvviso [*suddenly*]

ad un certo punto [*at a certain point*]

per + any length of time

Key expressions that usually require the use of the *imperfetto*:

quando (with the connotation of *every time*)
 fame da lupo.

mentre [*while*]
 guardava un film / sua sorella ha guardato un film.

da bambino(a), da piccolo(a), da giovane...
 montagna.

di solito, normalmente [*usually*]

Quando sono arrivato da Marco, abbiamo

All'improvviso non **ho visto** più niente.

Ad un certo punto lei **ha pianto**.

Abbiamo studiato per tre ore.

Quando finivo l'allenamento, avevo sempre una

Mentre Luigi **faceva** i compiti, sua sorella

Da giovane la nonna **preferiva** il mare alla

Di solito andavamo a dormire presto.

To conjugate the verb according to the subject that performs the action, **drop the –are, –ere, or –ire** and add the following endings:

giocare	scrivere	preferire	divertirsi
[io] gioc avo	[io] scrive vo	[io] prefer ivo	[io] mi divert ivo
[tu] gioc avi	[tu] scrive vi	[tu] prefer ivi	[tu] ti divert ivi
[lui, lei] gioc ava	[lui, lei] scrive va	[lui, lei] prefer iva	[lui, lei] si divert iva
[noi] gioc avamo	[noi] scrive vamo	[noi] prefer ivamo	[noi] ci divert ivamo
[voi] gioc avate	[voi] scrive vate	[voi] prefer ivate	[voi] vi divert ivate
[loro] gioc avano	[loro] scrive vano	[loro] prefer ivano	[loro] si divert ivano

Very few verbs are irregular in the *imperfetto*:

essere	fare	dire	bere
[io] ero	[io] facevo	[io] dicevo	[io] bevevo
[tu] eri	[tu] facevi	[tu] dicevi	[tu] bevevi
[lui, lei, Lei] era	[lui, lei, Lei] faceva	[lui, lei, Lei] diceva	[lui, lei, Lei] beveva
[noi] eravamo	[noi] facevamo	[noi] dicevamo	[noi] bevevamo
[voi] eravate	[voi] facevate	[voi] dicevate	[voi] bevevate
[loro] erano	[loro] facevano	[loro] dicevano	[loro] bevevano

The imperfetto of the verb *piacere*

- **Mi piaceva** ascoltare le storie di mio nonno.
- **Mi piaceva** la pipa di mio nonno.
- **Mi piacevano** le storie di mio nonno.

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2.02: Il "si" impersonale e passivante

Impersonal and passive si

Remember those useful phrases you learned in your first Italian class – **Come si dice...**? [How do you say...?] **Come si scrive...**? [How do you write/spell...?] and **Come si legge...**? [How do you read/pronounce...?] The word **si** has a general meaning of **people, everybody, one**, and an unspecified **you**, and it is often used in Italian to express actions that are common to many people.

1	si + verb in the 3rd-person singular when the direct object that follows the action is singular	Al bar in Piazza Dante si guarda la partita di Coppa Campioni.
2	si + verb in the 3rd-person plural when the direct object that follows the action is plural	Al bar in Piazza Dante si guardano le partite di Coppa Campioni.
3	si + verb in the 3rd person singular with verbs that are not followed by a direct object	La domenica si va allo stadio.
4	ci si + verb in the 3rd-person singular with reflexive verbs	Ci si diverte allo stadio.

There are theoretical differences between the **passive si** (in the first two cases above) and **impersonal si** (in the third and fourth cases above). Do not worry about them, as **si** means the same thing in both cases.

Notice that:

- A. **Si** can also mean *we*, as in **Si va?** [Shall we go?].
- B. With **si**, we use adjectives in the masculine plural form, because **si** has a plural connotation (people, everybody, one, an unspecified you), as in **Quando si perde una partita si è delusi** [When one loses a game one is disappointed = When people lose a game people are disappointed].
- C. **Si** can be used with all tenses:
- Present tense: *Oggi giorno **si giocano** alcune partite il sabato.*
 - Imperfetto: *Un tempo **si giocavano** tutte le partite la domenica.*
 - Passato prossimo: *Ieri sera **si è giocato** a calcio.* In a compound tense one always uses **essere** with **si**.
 - and other tenses you will learn.
- D. Do not confuse the **passive and impersonal si** [In questa lavanderia **si lavano** i cappotti] with the **reflexive si** [Lui **si lava** le mani].

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2.03: Alle superiori

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2.04: Le parti del corpo

“La Madonna dal collo lungo”
di Parmigianino (1503-1540)
c. 1535-40



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2.05: La mia infanzia

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2.06: Il portafoglio

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2.07: A chi assomigli

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3.01: Il partitivo

Expressing the partitive

How do you express an approximate quantity in Italian? There are several ways to say **some** (or **any**, if in a question) in Italian. The following structure is used when followed by any noun, whether it is something you can easily count (countable) or not easily count (uncountable). As in English, countables take the plural form (some berries), while uncountables remain singular (some coffee):

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1. Preposition di + definite article [<i>some; any</i>] | Vorrei <i>del</i> pane, per favore.
Vorrei <i>dello</i> zucchero, per favore.
Vorrei <i>dell'</i> acqua, per favore.
Vorrei <i>dei</i> mirtilli, per favore.
Vorrei <i>degli</i> zucchini, per favore.
Vorrei <i>delle</i> mele, per favore. |
|---|---|

There are two more options , but they may only be used with nouns that can be easily counted (countables):

- | | |
|--|--|
| 2. qualche [<i>some; any</i>] takes a singular noun in Italian | Vorrei <i>qualche</i> limone, per favore.
Vorrei <i>qualche</i> patata, per favore. |
|--|--|

- | | |
|--|--|
| 3. alcuni / alcune [<i>some; any</i>] takes a plural noun in Italian | Vorrei <i>alcuni</i> limoni, per favore.
Vorrei <i>alcune</i> patate, per favore. |
|--|--|

You could also say **un po' di** [*a bit of*] for a slightly different nuance, as in *Vorrei un po' di burro*.

So: how can you say *I'm going to buy some bottles of wine*?

1. **Compro delle bottiglie di vino.**
2. **Compro qualche bottiglia di vino.**
3. **Compro alcune bottiglie di vino.**

Notice that for grocery shopping, especially fruits and vegetables, **di + article** is the preferred and most often chosen option.

And how can you say *I drink some milk*? **Bevo del latte** is the only option, as *latte* is considered uncountable. However, if you are drinking glasses of milk, then you can technically count the glasses, and say, for example **bevo qualche bicchiere di latte** and **bevo alcuni bicchieri di latte**.

In Italian you may not use the partitive in a negative sentence, as in **non bevo latte** and **non compro fragole**.

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3.02: Al negozio di alimentari



A Roma, estate 2018.

Alcuni tipi di salumi

- il salame: il salame piccante; la finocchiona; la soppressata
- la mortadella [*bologna*]
- il prosciutto crudo [*prosciutto*]
- il prosciutto cotto [*ham*]
- il capocollo
- lo speck

Alcuni tipi di formaggi

- la mozzarella
- la robiola
- il Parmigiano Reggiano
- il Grana Padano
- il Bra piemontese
- il pecorino di Fossa
- la caciotta di pecora di Norcia
- il bastardo del Grappa
- il canestrato romano
- il caciocavallo
- il provolone
- il gorgonzola

E tantissimi altri!

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3.03: Salumi e formaggi



Un negozio di alimentari a Roma, 2018.

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3.04: Il pronome "ne"

The pronoun ne

Ne is a tricky little word because it is essential in Italian while there is no exact equivalent in English. Consider the example:

- Anna: Quanti pomodori usi per fare il sugo? [*How many tomatoes are you using to make the sauce?*]
- Giuseppe: **Ne** uso sei o sette. [*I use six or seven (of them).*]

As you can see, in English it is not necessary to say **of them**, but in Italian you absolutely have to use **ne** (which here means “of them”). Keep in mind the following:

- **Ne** means **of it** or **of them**.
- **Ne** usually answers the questions **Quanto? Quanta? Quanti? Quante?** [*How much? How many?*], whether the question is explicit or just implied.
- **Ne** is usually followed by a quantity of some kind, like a number or an amount.

Some more examples:

- Quanti anni hai? > **Ne** ho 19.
- Non mangio molto pesce: **ne** mangio solo un po' la domenica.
- Hai della farina? > No, non **ne** ho.

As is the case for **ci**, **ne** always goes before the conjugated verb, i.e.: *ne mangio, ne ho 20*, etc. However, when there is a verb + an infinitive, it can go either before the conjugated verb or be attached to the end of the infinitive after you have dropped the last letter of the infinitive, as in **comprare** > **comprar**. Consider the two possible answers to the following question:

Hai già comprato la farina per fare la focaccia?

- Sì, ma **ne devo comprare** ancora un po'.
- Sì, ma **devo comprarne** ancora un po'.

Ne is also used in many common phrases not only to mean **of it/of them**, but also to mean **about it**. We are not going to go into detail on this in this course; simply memorize the following expressions:

- **Cosa ne dici?** [*What do you say about it?*]
- **Cosa ne pensi?** [*What do you think about it?*]
- **Cosa ne sai?** [*What do you know about it?*] and **Ne sai qualcosa?** [*Do you know anything about it?*]
- **Non me ne importa; non me ne importa niente** [*I don't care about it; I don't care about it at all.*]
- **Non me ne frega niente!** [*I don't give a damn about it!*] and **Chi se ne frega!** [*Who cares!*] which are not very nice things to tell someone.

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3.05: I pronomi diretti

Direct object pronouns

First of all: what is a direct object? Anything that can answer the questions **What?** and **Who?** is a direct object, as in **Compro i peperoni** and **Oggi vedo mia sorella**, where **peperoni** and **mia sorella** are direct objects of the verbs **comprare** and **vedere**. Consider the following example:

Stamattina ho comprato i peperoni al mercato e ora **li** preparo.

In the example above, **li** stands for **i peperoni**. We use **li** to avoid repeating the word **peperoni**. **Li** is a pronoun, that is, it stands in the place of a noun, in this case, a direct object. Here is the complete list of direct pronouns:

mi [<i>me</i>]	ci [<i>us</i>]
ti [<i>you</i>]	vi [<i>you guys</i>]
lo [<i>him – a person, masculine singular; it – a masculine singular object</i>]	li [<i>them – objects and people, masculine plural</i>]
la [<i>her – a person, feminine singular; it – a feminine singular object</i>]	le [<i>them – objects and people, feminine plural</i>]

Like **ci** and **ne**, these pronouns always go before the conjugated verb, i.e.: *la compro*, *vi vedo*, etc. However, when there is a verb + an infinitive, it can go either before the conjugated verb or be attached to the end of the infinitive after you have dropped the last letter of the infinitive, as in **assaggiare** > **assaggiar**. Consider the two possible answers to the following question:

Hai già assaggiato la frittata?

- No, ma **la voglio assaggiare** subito.
- No, ma **voglio assaggiarla** subito.

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3.06: Un ristorante di cucina genovese



Ecco un pranzo al ristorante genovese [Eianda](#), che si trova in [contrada Mondovì a Cuneo](#) (Piemonte).

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3.07: I pronomi diretti con "avere"

Direct pronouns with verb avere

Consider the following example:

- Hai una sigaretta?
- Sì, **ce l'ho**.

This is an extremely common and uniquely Italian way of speech. Italians use **ce** + direct pronouns **lo**, **la**, **li**, **le** and **ne** when they answer a question about what they have or don't have. Here is the full explanation:

ce l'ho [<i>l' can be for both lo and la</i>]	<i>I have it</i>
ce li ho	<i>I have them</i>
ce le ho	<i>I have them</i>
ce ne ho	<i>I have some of it / of them</i>

In spoken Italian you can hear people say *c'ho fame* or *c'ho sete* or *c'ho i soldi* instead of *ho fame*, *ho sete* and *ho i soldi*. To find out why, you can view this interesting explanation on Alma TV: <https://www.almaedizioni.it/it/almatv/grammatica-caffe/chi-ce-lha/>

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3.08: I pronomi diretti con il passato prossimo

Direct object pronouns with the passato prossimo

You have learned that when you use **avere** in the **passato prossimo**, as in *ho visto un bel film* or *abbiamo finito di fare la spesa*, **visto** and **finito** do not change, no matter who is performing the action. There is one exception to this rule: when the direct object pronouns **lo**, **la**, **li**, **le** and **ne** precede the *passato prossimo*, the past participle (**visto** and **finito** in our examples) changes to agree with the direct object pronoun. Study all the following cases:

Hai preso il prosciutto? → Sì, **l'**ho preso. [**lo ho preso** becomes **l'ho preso**]

Hai preso la torta? → Sì, **l'**ho presa. [**la ho presa** becomes **l'ho presa**]

Hai preso i limoni? → Sì, **li** ho presi.

Hai preso le arance? → Sì, **le** ho prese.

Quante arance hai preso? → **Ne** ho prese quattro. / **Ne** ho presa una.

With the direct object pronouns **mi**, **ti**, **ci** and **vi**, you do not have to do this agreement, but you may.

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3.09: Il passato prossimo di "piacere"

The passato prossimo of piacere

Consider the following example:

- Antonio: Hai assaggiato la torta alla nutella?
- Stefania: Sì, e mi è piaciuta moltissimo.

Piacere has a very particular conjugation in the *passato prossimo*, because what Stefania is saying in Italian literally means that “the nutella cake was pleasing to me.”

Here are the possibilities for *piacere* in the *passato prossimo*.

è piaciuto + singular masculine subject	Mi è piaciuto il risotto che hai preparato.
è piaciuto + one or more infinitives	Mi è piaciuto fare la torta con te.
è piaciuta + singular feminine subject	Mi è piaciuta la pasta che hai preparato.
sono piaciuti + plural masculine subject	Non mi sono piaciuti i biscotti che hai preparato.
sono piaciute + plural feminine subject	Non mi sono piaciute le tagliatelle che hai preparato.

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3.10: Frutta dal fruttivendolo



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3.11: Frutta e verdura dal fruttivendolo



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3.12: Pesi e misure

Weights and measurements

In Italy (and in much of the world) people use the metric system, so when you go grocery shopping you need to be aware that you will order:

100 grammi (gr) di prosciutto / un etto di prosciutto	= 0.22 lb / 3.5 oz
200 grammi di parmigiano / due etti di parmigiano	= 0.44 lb / 7 oz
mezzo chilo (kg) di grissini	= 500 gr = 1.1 lb
un chilo di grissini	= 1000 gr = 2.2 lb
un litro (l) di latte	= 33 oz
3.78 l	= 1 gal

Here is a typical conversation at the market in Italy:

- Il negoziante: Buongiorno, desidera?
- Il cliente: Allora, vorrei due etti di parmigiano, tre etti di prosciutto crudo e un chilo di pane.
- Il negoziante: Basta così?
- Il cliente: E poi vorrei delle olive nere.
- Il negoziante: Quante ne vuole?
- Il cliente: Ma... ne prendo un etto.
- Il negoziante: Basta così?
- Il cliente: Sì, grazie. Quanto fa?
- Il negoziante: In tutto sono 11 euro e 40.
- Il cliente: Ecco a Lei. Arrivederci e grazie.
- Il negoziante: Grazie a Lei, arrivederci!

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3.13: Un piatto estivo



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3.14: Dimmi cosa mangi

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Clicca qui per vedere il video:

https://video.muhlenberg.edu/media/Dimmi+cosa+mangi/1_6muyjv1c

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3.15: Pranzo e cena

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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4.01: I pronomi indiretti

Indirect object pronouns

First of all: what is an indirect object? Anything that can answer the questions **To whom?** and **For whom?** is an indirect object, as in **Parlo a mio fratello** and **Oggi preparo una torta per Luisa**, where **a mio fratello** and **per Luisa** are indirect objects of the verbs **parlare** and **preparare**. Indirect objects almost always refer to people. Consider the following example:

- Hai già telefonato alla zia?
- No, le telefono dopo cena.

In the example above, **le** stands for **alla zia**. We use **le** to avoid repeating **alla zia**. **Le** is a pronoun, that is, it stands in the place of a noun, in this case, an indirect object. Here is the complete list of indirect pronouns:

mi = a me	ci = a noi
ti = a te	vi = a voi
gli = a lui	gli or loro = a loro
le = a lei	

Like **all pronouns**, these pronouns always go before the conjugated verb, i.e.: *mi telefoni, gli rispondo*, etc. **except for loro**. You can either say **io gli parlo** or **io parlo loro** [*I talk to them*].

However, when there is a verb + an infinitive, it can go either before the conjugated verb or be attached to the end of the infinitive after you have dropped the last letter of the infinitive, as in **scrivere** > **scriver**. Consider the two possible answers to the following question:

Hai già scritto al nonno?

- No, ma **gli voglio scrivere** presto.
- No, ma **voglio scrivergli** presto.

As you already know, the verb **piacere** comes with indirect pronouns. Here are more verbs that commonly use indirect objects:

chiedere (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo chiesto consiglio a Carlo.
consigliare (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo consigliato a Carlo di mangiare più leggero.
dare (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo dato la macchina a Carlo.
dire (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo detto un segreto a Carlo.
insegnare (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo insegnato una lezione a Carlo.
mandare (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo mandato un sms a Carlo.
offrire (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo offerto una cena a Carlo.
parlare a qualcuno	Abbiamo parlato a Carlo.
prestare (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo prestato la bici a Carlo.
regalare (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo regalato un braccialetto a Carlo.
rispondere a qualcuno	Abbiamo risposto a Carlo.
scrivere (qualcosa) a qualcuno	Abbiamo scritto una lettera a Carlo.
telefonare a qualcuno	Abbiamo telefonato a Carlo.

We can also:

- **comprare** qualcosa, **cucinare** qualcosa, **fare** qualcosa, **preparare** qualcosa **a** / **per** qualcuno
- **portare** [*to bring*] qualcosa, **restituire** [*to return*] qualcosa **a** qualcuno.

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4.02: Il condizionale presente

The present conditional

We use the conditional to say what we **would** do or what **would** happen. It expresses possibility:

Io **verrei** alla tua festa, ma ho troppo lavoro da fare. [*I would come to your party, but I have too much work to do.*]

We also use the conditional to request things politely:

Mi **aiuteresti**, per favore? [*Would you help me, please?*]

To conjugate the verb according to the subject that performs the action:

- drop the final **-e** of the infinitive;
- for **-ARE** verbs, change the **-a** of the infinitive to **-e** (practically speaking, **-are** and **-ere** verbs share the same conjugation);
- add the following endings:

	diventare	prendere	aprire	sentirsi
[io]	divent erei	prend erei	apri rei	mi sent irei
[tu]	divent eresti	prend eresti	apri resti	ti sent iresti
[lui, lei]	divent erebbe	prend erebbe	apri rebbe	si sent irebbe
[noi]	divent eremmo	prend eremmo	apri remmo	ci sent iremmo
[voi]	divent ereste	prend ereste	apri reste	vi sent ireste
[loro]	divent erebbero	prend erebbero	apri rebbero	si sent irebbero

Exceptions and particular cases

- Verbs in **-care** and **-gare** add an **h** so as to keep the same sound, as in **cercare**: io **cercherei** un lavoro lontano da casa.
- Verbs in **-ciare** and **-giare** drop the **i** of the infinitive, as in **cominciare**: io **comincerei** a lavorare il 3 aprile.
- These short verbs in **-are** do **not** change the **-a** to **-e**: **dare** → **darei**; **fare** → **farei**; **stare** → **starei**.

- There are many irregular verbs:

andare	andrei, andresti...
avere	avrei, avresti...
bere	berrei, berresti...
cadere	cadrei, cadresti...
dire	direi, diresti...
dovere	dovrei, dovresti...
essere	sarei, saresti...
* piacere	mi, ti ecc. piacerebbe (piacerebbero)
potere	potrei, potresti...
rimanere	rimarrei, rimarresti...
sapere	saprei, sapresti...
tenere	terrei, terresti...
vedere	vedrei, vedresti...
venire	verrei, verresti...
vivere	vivrei, vivresti...
volere	vorrei, vorresti...

We also use the conditional to express advice. Notice that the conditional of **dovere** → **dovrei, dovresti**, etc. translates into the English **should**.

Secondo me, **dovresti** aggiornare il tuo curriculum. [*I think you should update your resume.*]

Another way to express advice and points of view is the following, which translates into the English **If I were you** (or **if you were me**, etc.)

al posto mio [<i>in my place</i>]	Al posto mio, lui non lascerebbe questo lavoro.
al posto tuo [<i>in your place</i>]	Al posto tuo, io non lascerei questo lavoro.
al posto suo [<i>in his/her place</i>]	Al posto suo, non lascerei questo lavoro.
al posto nostro [<i>in our place</i>]	Al posto nostro, loro non lascerebbero questo lavoro.
al posto vostro [<i>in your place</i>]	Al posto vostro, noi non lasceremmo questo lavoro.
al posto loro [<i>in their place</i>]	Al posto loro, io non lascerei questo lavoro.

Also: *al posto di Maria, al posto di mio padre*, etc.

Good news: the future tense, which you will soon study, uses the same root forms as the conditional tense, just different endings!

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4.03: Il comparativo

The comparative

In Italian we use **più di/che** [*more than*] and **meno di/che** [*less than*] to compare two items (two people, two objects, two places, two activities, etc.).

There is no form like *-er* in Italian (*Evviva!* One less thing to learn.)

Più di and meno di

- We use **più di** and **meno di** when comparing two items with one adjective:

Questi pantaloni sono **più leggeri di** quelli. [*These pants are lighter than those.*]

Questi pantaloni sono **meno leggeri di** quelli. [*These pants are less light than those.*]

- We use **più di** and **meno di** with adverbs:

Luca si veste **più elegantemente di** me. [*Luca dresses more elegantly than me.*]

Luca si veste **meno elegantemente di** me. [*Luca dresses less elegantly than me.*]

Often, you will have to use the compound preposition **di + articles**:

La mia gonna è **più cara della** tua. [*di + la tua = della tua*] [*My skirt is more expensive than yours.*]

I miei occhiali da sole sono **meno cari degli** occhiali da sole di Anastasia. [*di + gli occhiali = degli occhiali*] [*My sunglasses are less expensive than Anastasia's sunglasses.*]

Più che and meno che

- We use **più che** and **meno che** when comparing two activities (two verbs):

Fare shopping è meno divertente che andare a ballare. [*Going shopping is less fun than going dancing.*]

- We use **più che** and **meno che** when comparing quantities:

Ci sono **più magliette che scarpe** nel tuo armadio. [*There are more t-shirts than shoes in your closet.*]

- We use **più che** and **meno che** when comparing two qualities of the same item:

Il vestito di Roberta è **più stravagante che originale.** [*Roberta's dress is weirder than it is original.*]

- We use **più che** and **meno che** before a preposition:

Ci sono **meno** negozi d'abbigliamento a Torino **che a** Milano. [*There are fewer clothing stores in Turin than in Milan.*]

(Tanto) quanto and come

- To say that two items are equal we use **(tanto) ... quanto** and **come** [*as...as*]:

La tua borsa è **tanto** grande **quanto** la sua. [*Your purse is as big as hers.*]

La tua borsa è grande **quanto** la sua. [*Your purse is as big as hers.*]

La tua borsa è grande **come** la sua. [*Your purse is as big as hers.*]

- When comparing quantities, **tanto** and **quanto** must agree with the items they refer to:

Ho **tanti** jeans **quante** gonne. [*I have as many jeans as I have skirts.*]

4.04: I comparativi irregolari

Irregular comparative forms

As in English, there are a few irregular adjectives and adverbs in the comparative form.

Adjectives		Irregular comparative adjectives	
buono	<i>good</i>	migliore	<i>better</i>
cattivo/brutto	<i>bad</i>	peggiore	<i>worse</i>
grande	<i>big</i>	maggiore	<i>bigger / older</i>
piccolo	<i>small</i>	minore	<i>smaller / younger</i>
Adverbs		Irregular comparative adverbs	
bene	<i>well</i>	meglio	<i>better</i>
male	<i>badly / poorly</i>	peggio	<i>worse</i>

You can also use the forms **più + adjective**, as in **più buono**, **più grande**, etc. However, there are some nuances:

- **maggiore** and **minore** are most often used to talk about siblings, as in **il mio fratello maggiore**, **la mia sorella minore**.
- **più grande** and **più piccolo** are used to talk about size, as in **questa borsa è più piccola di quella**.
- **più buono** and **più cattivo** usually refer to a moral quality, as in **Gianni è più buono di te** and food, as in **la pizza margherita è più buona della pizza alla diavola**.

You cannot say *più bene* or *più male*. Only the irregular forms are acceptable.

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4.05: Che lavoro ti piacerebbe fare

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4.06: I miei sogni

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4.07: Cosa faresti con 100 mila euro?

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4.08: Cos'è meglio?

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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5.01: Il superlativo relativo

The relative superlative

When you say a song is **the most beautiful of all**, or a boy is **the nicest in the class**, or the verb *essere* is **the most difficult of all verbs**, then you are using the relative superlative. See how it works in Italian:

I treni Frecciarossa sono **i più veloci** di tutti. [*Frecciarossa trains are the fastest trains of all.*]

I treni regionali sono **i meno veloci** di tutti. [*Regional trains are the slowest trains of all.*]

To specify what or who is the fastest, the least practical, etc. in a group or category, Italians use the preposition **di**. The superlative can be formed in a few ways:

definite article	noun	più / meno + adjective	di + a group, the world, all, etc...
il	treno	più veloce	di tutti
i	treni	più veloci	di tutti
la	macchina	meno veloce	di tutte
le	macchine	meno veloci	di tutte

definite article	più / meno + adjective	di + a group, the world, all, etc...
il	più veloce	di tutti
i	più veloci	di tutti
la	meno veloce	di tutte
le	meno veloci	di tutte

Only with short adjectives that can precede the noun, i.e. **bello, brutto, vecchio, giovane, grande, piccolo**, you can have the following word order:

definite article	più + short adjective	noun	di + a group, the world, all, etc...
il	più bel	momento	del viaggio
i	più bei	momenti	del viaggio
la	più bella	passeggiata	del viaggio
le	più belle	passegiate	del viaggio

You can also say **tra** or **fra** [*among*] instead of **di** when referring to a plural noun, such as, **La British Airlines è la compagnia che ha più voli fra tutte le compagnie aeree**. If the noun is singular, then use **di**: **La Vespa è lo scooter più bello del mondo**.

There is no form like *-est* in Italian (*Evviva!* One less thing to learn.)

Irregular superlative forms

The irregular adjectives in the superlative form are the same as those in the comparative form, with the addition of the definite articles:

Adjectives		Irregular superlative adjectives	
buono	<i>good</i>	il / la migliore; i / le migliori	<i>the best</i>
cattivo/brutto	<i>bad</i>	il / la peggiore; i / le peggiori	<i>the worst</i>
grande	<i>big</i>	il / la maggiore; i / le maggiori	<i>the biggest / oldest</i>
piccolo	<i>small</i>	il / la minore; i / le minori	<i>the smallest / youngest</i>

The superlative and comparative forms of irregular adverbs are the same:

Adverbs		Irregular superlative adverbs	
bene	<i>well</i>	meglio	<i>best</i>
male	<i>badly</i>	peggio	<i>worst</i>

Consider the examples:

- Questa bicicletta è migliore di quella. (comparative)
- Questa bicicletta è la migliore! (superlative)
- Paolo guida peggio di me. (comparative)
- Paolo guida peggio di tutti! (superlative)

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5.02: Il superlativo assoluto

Absolute superlative

Bellissimo! might be what you would say when admiring Michelangelo's *David* or a breathtaking view in the Dolomites. **Bellissimo** means *very beautiful, extremely beautiful*: the suffixes **-issimo** / **-issima** / **-issimi** / **-issime** take the place of *very* and *extremely*. Consider the examples:

Il panorama di qui è **bellissimo**. [*The landscape from here is very beautiful.*]

I camerieri in questo ristorante sono **gentilissimi**. [*The waiters in this restaurant are very kind.*]

La prenotazione è stata **facilissima**. [*The reservation was very easy to make.*]

Le camere da letto di questo albergo sono **grandissime**. [*The rooms in this hotel are very big.*]

To form this superlative, simply drop the last letter of the adjective, as in **bello** → **bell**; **gentile** → **gentil**, etc., and add the **-issimo** / **-issima** / **-issimi** / **-issime** forms.

You can also use this superlative for adverbs, such as **bene** → **ben** → **benissimo**, and **male** → **mal** → **malissimo**.

Notice that:

- there are a few special forms: **ottimo** is a synonym of **buonissimo**, and **pessimo** is a synonym of **cattivissimo**.
- you cannot use this superlative for adjectives that already have a very strong meaning, such as **delizioso**, **fantastico**, **meraviglioso**, **stupendo**, **orribile** and **terribile**.
- you can either say **molto** + **adjective** or **adjective** + **-issimo**, but you cannot combine the two forms and say *molto gentilissimo*, for example.

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5.03: Il futuro semplice

Simple future

We use the future tense to say what we **will** do, what we **are going to** do, or what **will** happen. Italians use it especially to make any kind of prediction or forecast:

Secondo me, la Juventus **vincerà** il campionato. [*In my opinion, Juventus will win the league championship.*]

Quando **sarò** grande, **farò** il pompiere. [*I will be a firefighter when I grow up.*]

Se **continuerà** a nevicare, gli aerei non **partiranno**. [*If it continues to snow, the planes will not leave.*]

Notice that in Italian, unlike in English, we can use the future tense after **se** [if] and **quando** [when].

As you already know, Italians may also use the present tense to talk about the (near) future and their plans:

Domani **partiamo** per il Marocco. [*Tomorrow we're leaving for Morocco.*]

Stasera non **torno** a casa: **devo** finire un lavoro. [*I'm not coming home tonight: I have to finish a job.*]

To conjugate the verb according to the subject that performs the action, you do the same thing as for the present conditional:

- **drop the final -e of the infinitive;**
- **change the -a in the infinitive of -are verbs to -e (practically, -are and -ere verbs share the same conjugation);**
- **add the following endings:**

diventare	prendere	aprire	sentirsi
[io] diventerò	[io] prenderò	[io] aprirò	[io] mi sentirò
[tu] diventerai	[tu] prenderai	[tu] aprirai	[tu] ti sentirai
[lui, lei] diventerà	[lui, lei] prenderà	[lui, lei] aprirà	[lui, lei] si sentirà
[noi] diventeremo	[noi] prenderemo	[noi] apriremo	[noi] ci sentiremo
[voi] diventerete	[voi] prenderete	[voi] aprirete	[voi] vi sentirete
[loro] diventeranno	[loro] prenderanno	[loro] apriranno	[loro] si sentiranno

Verbs that are irregular in the present conditional will also be irregular in the future tense. Consider the two similar conjugations side-by-side:

Conditional of <i>volere</i> [would want]	Future of <i>volere</i> [will want]
[io] vorrei	[io] vorrò
[tu] vorresti	[tu] vorrai
[lui, lei] vorrebbe	[lui, lei] vorrà
[noi] vorremmo	[noi] vorremo
[voi] vorreste	[voi] vorrete
[loro] vorrebbero	[loro] vorranno

Here are some time expressions that are commonly used with the future tense:

prossimo [next] → l'anno prossimo, la settimana prossima, sabato prossimo...

fra [*in*] → fra due giorni, fra tre mesi, fra cinque anni...

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5.04: Mezzi di trasporto

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5.05: A Torino

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5.06: A Lecce

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5.07: Previsioni del futuro

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